

response times were often too slow and accuracy lacking. Time and again, Allied aircraft hit their own troops instead of the enemy – making soldiers inclined to fire on any airplane, whether “friendly” or not. Airmen were sometimes made to spend time with troops in the front line to gain an appreciation of the ground forces’ perspective, but it made little difference. But this is not to deny the impact ground-attack aircraft had on the battles in western Europe in 1944–45. Fighter-bombers such as the Hawker Typhoon and P-47 Thunderbolt earned a fearsome reputation for their striking power with machine guns, cannon, bombs, and rockets. Napalm was also part of the ground-attack armory. As on the eastern front, even heavily armored tanks proved vulnerable to air attack. The final German counter-attack in the Ardennes at Christmas 1944 was only possible because bad weather prevented Allied aircraft from operating.

As Allied fighters and fighter-bombers ranged over enemy-held areas – preying on trains, attacking airfields, shooting up convoys of trucks – they rarely suffered substantial losses at the hands of the heavily outnumbered German aircraft. But flak took a severe toll. Flying in at low altitude to strafe or bomb a target defended by AA guns required nerve and luck. Apart from

the chances of being hit by enemy fire, there was always a risk of flying straight into the target, or into a building or power pole. If the target exploded – because it was an ammunition truck, for example – the pilot might find himself careering through flying slabs of road or pieces of chassis. Most airmen consistently preferred the active challenge of air-to-air combat to the sense of passive vulnerability they felt in the face of ground fire.

Overwhelming air power

By the end of the war, both the German and Japanese air defenses had been totally overwhelmed by Allied air power. The scale of Allied air operations was quite phenomenal. In the American and British strategic air offensive in Europe, thousand-bomber raids became commonplace. The first day of the Arnhem airborne offensive in September 1944 involved more than 4,000 Allied transport aircraft, fighters, bombers, and gliders. In March 1945, during its final drive on Berlin, the Soviet air force carried out over 17,500 flights in a single day. Throughout the whole period of conflict, the United States had built almost



BOLT FROM THE BLUE

American ground crew service a P-47 Thunderbolt in England in 1943. Under the fuselage is a drop tank, providing extra fuel for increased range. The engine cowling was painted white to avoid confusion with the rather similar German Focke-Wulf Fw 190, which put Thunderbolts at risk from friendly fire.

300,000 military aircraft, and pilots were trained by the hundreds of thousands. The war left a sorrowful legacy of destruction, much of it caused by the deployment of air power. But another legacy of the war was flight on an unprecedented scale.

VIEW TO A KILL

FRENCH PILOT PIERRE CLOSTERMANN flew both with the Free French Air Force and the RAF during World War II. Clostermann described leading an attack by four Tempest fighter-bombers on a train in the winter of 1944 – a kind of operation he said was one of “those inhuman, immoral jobs we had to do because... war is war.”

“The four Tempests slid down to 3,000ft [900m] in the frozen air and their polished wings caught the first gleams of a dingy dawn. We oblied toward the train and instinctively four gloved hands, benumbed by the cold, were already pushing the prop lever to fine pitch. We could now make out the locomotive and the flak truck in front of it and the interminable mixed train dragging painfully behind.”

“Without dropping our auxiliary tanks, we went into a shallow dive at full throttle... 350... 380... 420... 450mph [550... 600... 675... 725kph]. The blood throbbed in my parched throat – still that old fear of flak. Only about a mile or two [1.5–3km] now. I began to set my aim for about 20 yards [18m] in front of the locomotive.”

“Now! I leant forward, tensed. Only 800 yards [730m]. The first burst of tracer – the staccato flashes of the quadruple 20-mm flak mounting – the locomotive’s wheels skidding with all brakes jammed on... I was skimming over the snow-covered furrowed fields. Rooks flew off in swarms.

My cannon roared – the engine driver jumped out of his cabin and rolled into the ditch. My shells exploded on the embankment and perforated the black shape which loomed in my sights.”

“Then the funnel vomited a hot blast of flame and cinders, enveloped in the steam escaping from the punctured pipes. A slight backward pressure on the stick to clear the telegraph wires, a quick dive through the smoke, then, once again, the sky in my windshield, covered with oily soot... A glance backward. The locomotive had disappeared, shrouded in soot and spurting steam. People were scrambling out of doors and tearing down the embankment like agitated ants.”

FRENCH FIGHTER ACE

French fighter pilot Pierre Clostermann settles into the cockpit of his Hawker Tempest, marked with a cross for each of his kills. Clostermann regarded the Tempest as the best Allied fighter aircraft of the war.

“Strafing of trains in the gray dawn... those inhuman, immoral jobs we had to do... because war is war.”

PIERRE CLOSTERMANN
THE BIG SHOW

